



Hamas reasserts control in Gaza

Militant group’s message carries huge implications for Trump’s peace plan

BY GERRY SHIH, ARI FLANZRAICH AND HAZEM BALOUSHA

JERUSALEM — They blindfolded eight men accused of collaborating with Israel, made them kneel and executed them at point-blank range on a busy street in Gaza City. They sent jeeps filled with fighters to pursue the Astal militia, whose leader said it coordinates with Israel and had recently taken up arms alongside other gangs.

They hunted the Mujaida clan until the family, decimated after a gun battle, announced that it would pledge fealty to the “government” of Gaza: Hamas.

Hamas may have stopped fighting Israel, but it has launched a new, violent campaign to reassert control over local families and militias that had challenged its power during the past two years of war — including those who, according to the leaders of two clans, had received support from Israel. Whether by carrying out armed raids in Deir al-Balah in the central Gaza Strip or holding public executions farther north in Gaza City, Hamas is trying to send a clear message that, after months of hiding from Israeli fire, the militant group is back as the only visible authority inside the Gaza Strip, according to rival militia leaders, Palestinian officials and political analysts.

Hamas’s enduring grip has significant implications for the future of Gaza and President Donald Trump’s peace plan. With Israel largely restrained from attacking Hamas under the ceasefire

SEE HAMAS ON A12

The Fourth Estate’s Pentagon exodus



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

Jared Szuba of Al-Monitor, a Middle East-focused news outlet, leaves the Pentagon on Wednesday along with journalists from dozens of other institutions that balked at new restrictions on newsgathering. **Story, A14**

Trump authorizes covert CIA action in Venezuela

BY WARREN P. STROBEL, JOHN HUDSON AND KAREN DEYOUNG

President Donald Trump said Wednesday that he had authorized the Central Intelligence Agency to conduct operations in Venezuela, markedly escalating U.S. pressure on President Nicolás Maduro amid a string of lethal strikes against alleged drug trafficking boats in Caribbean waters off that country’s coast.

Trump declined to say whether he had authorized the CIA to

overthrow Maduro, a step some of his top national security aides have urged. “I think Venezuela’s feeling the heat,” he said at a White House news conference.

The president was asked about reports that he signed a highly classified document, known as a “finding,” that allows the CIA to conduct covert operations in foreign countries, ranging from clandestine information operations to training guerrilla opposition forces and conducting lethal strikes. Trump’s order was reported earlier by the New York

Times. The details of the new authorities now available to the CIA remain unclear.

But people familiar with the matter said the spy agency has surged personnel to the Caribbean and Central America as part of the Trump administration’s move against Western Hemisphere drug cartels. They are there to collect intelligence, not conduct armed operations, said the people, who like some others spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive matters. CIA surveillance drones are also

prowl the skies above Mexico, searching for labs that make the deadly drug fentanyl, they said.

Trump’s top national security advisers have feuded bitterly over Venezuela policy, and whether to seek the overthrow of Maduro, whom Washington accuses of stealing last year’s Venezuelan presidential election. That course is favored by Secretary of State Marco Rubio and CIA Director John Ratcliffe, one of the people said. In August, Attorney General Pam Bondi

SEE CIA ON A5

More U.S. Jews shielding identity, poll finds

BY MICHELLE BOORSTEIN, SCOTT CLEMENT AND EMILY GUSKIN

U.S. Jews increasingly say they are hiding their identity in a country where they believe they continue to face significant antisemitism and where slightly fewer than 1 in 5 feel very safe, a Washington Post poll finds.

The nation’s 6 million Jewish adults also are skeptical of President Donald Trump’s campaign to fight antisemitism on college campuses, with nearly two-thirds suggesting he is conducting it for other reasons, according to the poll. Jews widely disapprove of Trump’s performance overall, the

Amid antisemitism fears, one-third say they don’t feel safe in the nation

results show.

The poll was conducted in early September, before Trump helped negotiate a ceasefire in the Israel-Gaza war and the release of Israeli hostages and Palestinian detainees.

Nearly half of U.S. Jews say there is “a lot” of antisemitism in the U.S., and a similar share say there is “some” — numbers almost identical to the results of a

Pew Research Center survey conducted five years ago.

A third say they don’t feel safe in the United States, and two-thirds report seeing antisemitic content online at least once a month. At the same time, a large majority — 73 percent — say they have not been the target of antisemitic remarks online or in person in the past year.

In one clear development, the poll finds 42 percent of Jewish Americans say they’ve avoided publicly wearing, carrying or displaying anything that might help people identify them as Jewish in the past year. That is up from 26 percent who said that to a similar

SEE POLL ON A18



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Dark visions of a return to Afghanistan

He escaped after supporting the U.S. It may now send him back.

BY JOHN WOODROW COX

In his cell, the light glows all night, so he pulls a blanket over his head and burrows into the darkness. Then comes his nightmare, about the Taliban fighter whose face appears in a cloud of black smoke, beard long, hand reaching toward him. He runs and he runs until he wakes up, gasping.

Now, in the light, he worries it’s not a dream

E, the wife of H, is overcome with emotion as she reads over her statement about why she fears returning to Afghanistan during a visit with attorney Amin Ganjalizadeh in Virginia.

but a vision of his future in Afghanistan, where he will be tortured and killed, where his wife will starve, where his son will be forced to join the militants, where his daughter will become an old man’s fourth wife.

This is the place the U.S. government delivered him out of and the place it intends to send him back to.

“I’m so scared from Taliban,” he said in a call

SEE AFGHANS ON A8

Study: Even light drinking can raise dementia risk

BY RICHARD SIMA

For years, the common wisdom and science was that a little bit of alcohol wasn’t bad — and even beneficial — for your health: a toast to moderation.

But new research published in BMJ Evidence-Based Medicine suggests that even light alcohol consumption can increase dementia risk.

The finding comes from data of more than 550,000 adults ages 56 to 72, as well as genetics information from 2.4 million study participants. It adds to evidence that

Research rebuts earlier findings that occasional alcohol use is beneficial

even small amounts of alcohol can be harmful to our health, including increasing the risk of cancer or disrupting sleep.

Excessive alcohol consumption — more than 12 drinks per week — and alcohol use disorder have long been linked to dementia, an umbrella term for different

types of progressive cognitive impairment, including Alzheimer’s disease.

But the science on an occasional glass of wine or beer had been more rosy. One influential study published in 2003 seemed to suggest that people who had one drink a day were actually less likely to get dementia than those who didn’t drink at all.

“For a long time we thought that the healthiest way to approach drinking and brain health was to take about a drink a day,” said Joel Gelernter, a professor of

SEE DEMENTIA ON A18

IN THE NEWS

Trump weighs in on sentencing Two teens arrested in connection with the attempted carjacking of a former DOGE staffer get probation, which the president criticized. B13

Voting Rights Act back in court Justices signaled an openness to a move that could undermine the law’s last major pillar. A2

THE NATION **Dozens of firms** have poured millions into the White House ballroom’s construction. A2 **Broadview**, a small Chicago suburb, is on the national stage amid ICE’s crackdown. A4

THE WORLD **Hegseth warns** the Kremlin of “costs” as the U.S. prods Russia to negotiate on Ukraine. A11 **Far-right** commentator Candace Owens has lost her legal fight to enter Australia. A12

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STYLE **Trump’s “gold card”** plan is a path to immigration — for people who can afford it. B1

SPORTS **The NFL season** is about one-third complete and two things have become clear: Parity rules, and there is no dominant team. Yet. B7

THE REGION **Georgetown** names Eduardo M. Peñalver, who leads Seattle University, as its next president. B13

LOCAL LIVING **Looking to steer** kids away from screens and social media, more families are going back to the landline.

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